

A NEW ROLE NCP working president Supriya Sule (in yellow) with party workers in Pune, June 11

to continue. Three days later, when Pawar announced he was withdrawing his decision, Ajit was missing at the presss conference.

While daughter Sule's appointment as the NCP working president was only to be expected, the choice of Patel came as a surprise. Sources say it was meant to balance the interests of the two competing groups in the party: one loyal to Pawar Sr, the other to Ajit—Patel is seen to belong to the latter camp. In another significant development, Sule has been given charge of Maharashtra—Ajit's turf—among other states. She has also been appointed chairperson of the NCP central election authority, giving her a significant say in selecting candidates for polls.

Dismissing all speculation, an NCP functionary says Sule and Patel's appointments were made after consulting Ajit. "He has no ambition to play a national role," he adds. "His focus is Maharashtra politics because his eventual ambition is to become chief minister." Confirmation of that comes from MVA ally Shiv Sena, as a senior leader of the Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray faction says, "Ajit now knows that if he wants to become CM, it is only the NCP that can help him realise that ambition. He cannot fulfill this desire by going over to the BJP."

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And the NCP perhaps needs him as much as he needs the party. As an NCP leader close to Ajit adds, "Despite any leadership transitions, it is Ajit dada who will call the shots. The decision has sealed Supriya tai's position as Pawar saheb's heir, but in Maharashtra, it is Ajit dada who is seen as a mass leader with granular knowledge about what is happening on the ground. No one can touch dada's pre-eminent position as it will result in a setback for the party." A senior Congress leader from western Maharashtra, where the NCP has a strong base, though, is unwilling to buy the argument, convinced that the latest move is an attempt to undermine Ajit's writ.

That said, Pawar Sr has been grooming his daughter for long, as a long-term associate of the family points out. "Sharad Pawar acted decisively when Ajit rebelled and took oath as the deputy CM with Devendra Fadnavis in 2019. He marshalled his forces and proved that he commands the NCP, forcing Ajit to resign in three days," he says. He also adds that in the event of a show of strength between the Pawar cousins, Sule could stand her ground. Her appointment is also seen as an attempt to give a suave, urbane image to a party that has a rural base. Patel is known for his network among corporates and across party lines in Delhi.

However, the NCP's detractors claim that Sule and Patel's appointments may widen the cleavages within the party. "It was speculated that Patel and Ajit Pawar wanted to split the party and go with the BJP," says MLA Sanjay Shirsat, spokesperson of the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena. "Pawar may now be trying to get Patel on his side to weaken Ajit."

Meanwhile, the NCP is also being accused of "perpetuating dynastic rule". Reacting to it, Sule said: "I accept it. There is *gharaneshahi* (family rule). How can I run away from it?" However, she added that she had proved her mettle as a parliamentarian through her performance. Sule is a three-term Lok Sabha MP from Baramati in Pune and has had a stint in the Rajya Sabha. She was clear about the party hierarchy too: "At the national level, I will report to Sharad Pawar and Praful Patel. In the state...to Ajit Pawar, Chhagan Bhujbal and (state NCP chief) Jayant Patil." Asked if Ajit was being sidelined, she denied it. "He is the leader of the opposition," she said, "which is equivalent to the post of the chief minister."

What will Ajit Pawar do? Vijay Chormare, senior journalist and analyst, says, "It will be evident in the coming days.... Even if Sule is the working president, Ajit's writ will run in party affairs in Maharashtra." He is too seasoned a politician to fade into insignificance. ■